ELIXIR-UK DaSH: A Fellowship of Data Stewards

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The project behind the Fellowship

In 2021, ELIXIR-UK was granted a UKRI award for the ELIXIR-UK DaSH project. The University of Bradford leads the project with a delivery team at Cardiff University, the Earlham Institute, the University of Manchester, and the University of Oxford.

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The project aims to embed Research Data Management (RDM) know-how into UK universities and institutes by producing and delivering training in Data Stewardship. It focuses on building capacity and professionalising the role of Data Stewards while leveraging the local expertise within diverse UK organisations.

Ultimately, the project aims to create a culture change with a Fellowship of Data Stewards. Fellows will act as ambassadors to embed RDM in their organisations.

The Fellowship: activities and goals

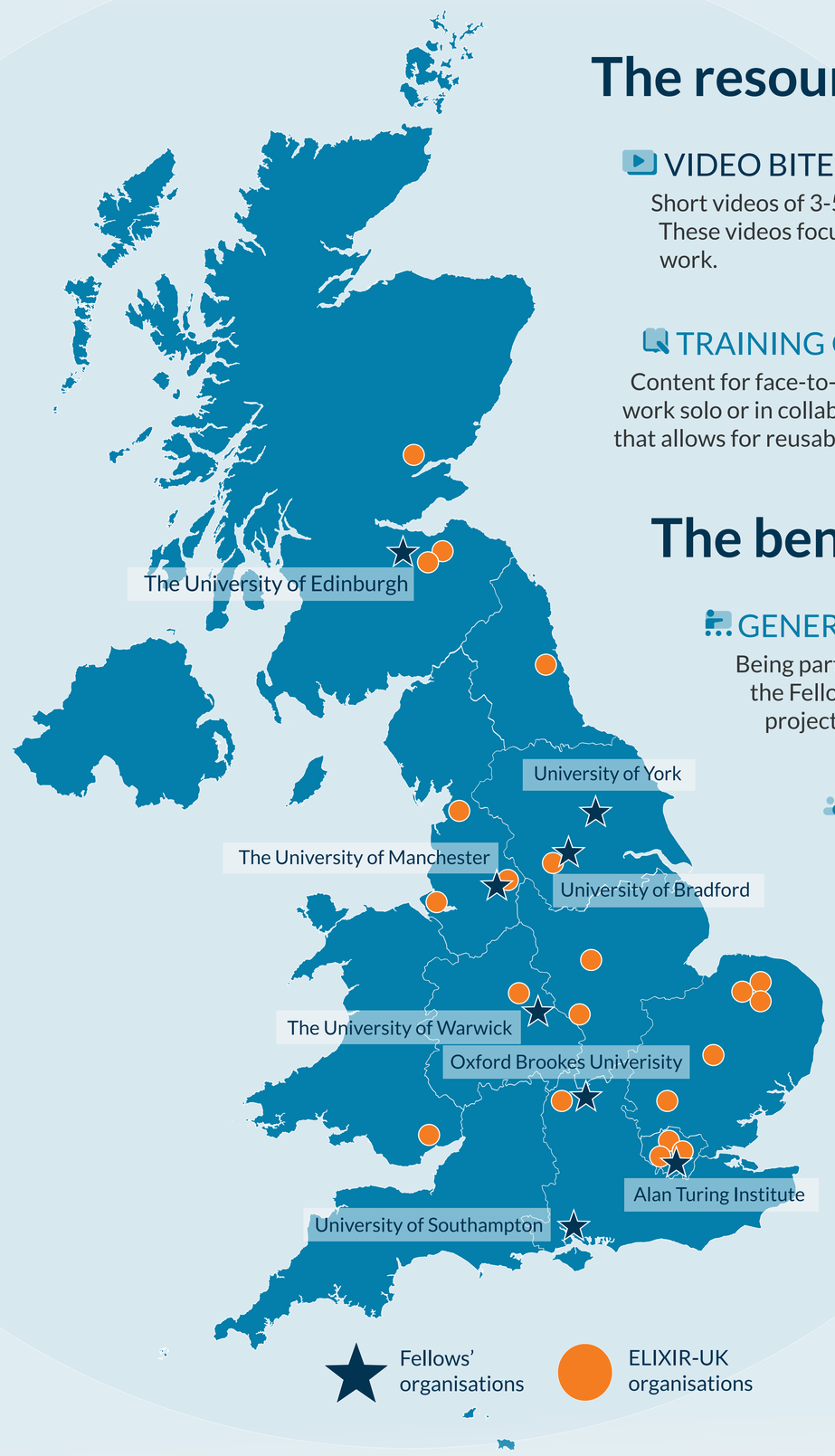
High quality and broad diversity

The Fellowship welcomes experts in data management in life sciences at any career stage, from PhD candidates to professors, and from any life sciences field.

The Fellows are a select group of data stewards. A panel of experts scrutinises applications in two stages: shortlisting and selection. All candidates must demonstrate a strong understanding of data management in their niche area and excellent communications skills to deliver training.

The work of the Fellows is also carefully reviewed. Together with an expert pool from ELIXIR-UK and beyond, the project team ensures that the content meets the quality standards for training delivery, accuracy and relevance.

The Fellowship produces factual, up-to-date and enticing RDM training materials.



The resources developed

VIDEO BITES

Short videos of 3-5 minutes on RDM aspects within Fellows' fields of expertise. These videos focus on relating basic concepts or signposting larger pieces of work.

TRAINING COURSES

Content for face-to-face and online courses on RDM and FAIR data. Fellows can work solo or in collaboration with other Fellows and trainers, using infrastructure that allows for reusability and scalability, such as The Carpentries.

The benefits

GENERATING RDM CAPACITY LOCALLY

Being part of the Fellowship entails organising training courses within the Fellow's institution or communities using material developed in the project.

SEEDING A LOCAL COMMUNITY OF PRACTICE

Delivering training courses locally and disseminating training materials helps get interested parties together. The activities of the Fellowship aim to help build the grassroots of a local community of practice.

ENHANCING TRAINING SKILLS

Fellows also benefit from ELIXIR training courses, including Train-the-Trainer and coaching relationships with other Fellows and trainers.

CONTRIBUTING TO INTERNATIONAL PROJECTS

Because the Fellowship is engrained in ELIXIR-UK, Fellows can contribute to RDM best practices and know-how in international resources: FAIR Cookbook, RDMkit.

The sustainability of the Fellowship

The Fellowship has the full support of the entire ELIXIR-UK Node –21 UK universities and institutes.

Additionally, the connection of ELIXIR-UK with the Software Sustainability Institute (SSI) informs the Fellowship's structure, processes and results. SSI has been running a successful fellowship for more than 10 years. The collaboration inspires best practices and avoids common pitfalls in running and building a community of practice.

Embedding RDM and FAIR principles

The project enables Fellows to contribute to two international RDM resources, gaining knowledge on the latest best practice and guidance and preparing them for advocacy to their own institutions and research areas.

Editors of the RDMkit, a community-led guide to data management, are part of the team of advisors and coordinators of the project.

The project engages with the FAIR Cookbook a practical step-by-step guide on implementing the FAIR principles (Findable, Accessible, Interoperable and Reusable).

This project was funded as part of the UKRI Innovation Scholars: Data Science Training in Health and Bioscience call (DaSH). (MR/V038966/1)

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